Galatians 1

Called by grace · Give God the glory

THE LETTER AT A GLANCE

Paul writes to churches in Galatia facing a question that reaches into our lives: Is Christ's saving work sufficient, or must we add something to be accepted by God? Chapters 1–2: the gospel received and defended. Chapters 3–4: faith, promise, law, and inheritance. Chapters 5–6: freedom, the Spirit, and life together. God's law is not the enemy; Paul challenges added requirements as the basis of our standing before God.

SCRIPTURE

Open your Bibles to **Galatians 1:1–24**. Galatians is a letter: Paul is making a case to churches he loves, so follow his reasoning. Chapter 1 moves from a greeting centered on Jesus (1:1–5), to Paul's alarm at a different gospel (1:6–10), to his own story of being called by grace (1:11–24). Watch for *grace*, *gospel*, and *called*.

Part 1 · Grace Begins with Jesus

Galatians 1:1–10

Paul begins with God's action. Jesus "gave himself for our sins to rescue us from this present evil age" (1:4). Sin is real, and grace does not ask us to hide it. Christ acts on our behalf, and God receives the glory. So Paul is alarmed that the churches are turning to a different gospel. Adding a condition to Christ's work changes the foundation we stand on. Service, prayer, and faithful responsibility are good, but if being useful, sounding assured, or keeping up with someone else becomes the reason God should accept us, our confidence has moved away from Christ. Another woman's apparent confidence does not make Jesus less sufficient for you.

DISCUSS

1. How would you explain the gospel to someone who asked what you believe? How does Jesus' self-giving in 1:3–5 shape your answer?
2. Where might approval, comparison, or appearing spiritually confident become an extra condition for feeling accepted by God?

Part 2 · A Servant of Christ, Called by Grace

Galatians 1:11–24

Paul has just asked, “Am I striving to please people? If I were still trying to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ” (1:10). His gospel came by a revelation of Jesus Christ, not from shaping it for approval (1:12). His past proves it: impressive religious zeal had been aimed against God’s church. Then God “called me by his grace” and revealed his Son in him (1:15–16).

The story ends in worship. The churches kept hearing that their former persecutor now preached the faith he once tried to destroy, “and they glorified God because of me” (1:24). Paul did not arrange his testimony to be admired.

When we tell what God has done, comparison can slip in: whose story sounds stronger, whose change looks cleaner. Grace gives our stories a different purpose. We tell the truth about mercy received, and we help one another notice God’s work without ranking it.

DISCUSS

1. In 1:10–12, what is Paul unwilling to live for, and where does he say his gospel came from?
2. When you speak about what God has done, what helps the glory stay with him? How could you notice his grace in another woman this week?

REFLECTIONS

1. Where do you notice yourself shaping your story so it will compare well?
2. Who is one woman you could encourage this week by naming what God has done in her?

CLOSE PRAYER

Father, thank you for calling us by grace and for revealing your Son. Bring us back to Christ when approval or comparison becomes our measure of worth. Teach us to tell the truth about your mercy and to give you glory for your work in one another. By your Spirit, make our encouragement faithful and kind. Amen.

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